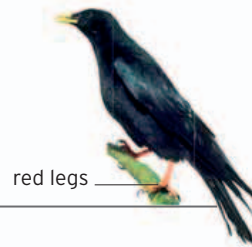


Yellow-billed chough

Pyrrhocorax graculus

Skiers and climbers in the high Alps are familiar with this elegant member of the crow family, but flocks of yellow-billed choughs are sometimes seen at much lower elevations, especially in the Balkans. These choughs often visit tourist sites in search of extra scraps of food. They form flocks that are hundreds strong

when feeding in green pastures or swirling effortlessly in a whirlwind over high peaks and deep corries. The yellow-billed chough's soft, lisping call notes are distinctive, as are its rounded tail and wings. Pairs form lifelong bonds and also remain faithful to a nest site, in a cave or rock crevice.



red legs

- ↔ 14–15 in (36–38 cm)
- ⚖ 6–9 oz (170–255 g)
- ⊗ Common
- 🍷 Insects, fruit
- 🏠



Europe, NW. Africa, W.
to C. Asia



◀ ON TOP OF THE WORLD

Flocks of yellow-billed choughs settle on high ridges and forage on alpine pastures. In the Himalayas they can reach altitudes as high as 26,250 ft (8,000 m).

Ptarmigan

Lagopus muta



feathered feet

Unusually for a gamebird, the ptarmigan is monogamous. Pairs stay together to protect their growing chicks, although sexes often separate when they form winter flocks. A high-altitude bird in most of Europe, the ptarmigan lives much lower in the far north and northwest, commonly at sea level in Iceland. It is feared that climate change may wipe out southern populations on lower ranges, as their habitat and climate “envelope” rises above the available peaks.

Ptarmigans molt through a sequence of white, salt-and-pepper, gray-and-white, and beautiful mottled plumages, keeping pace with the change from white-out snow to the rich colors of rock, gravel, moss, and lichen in summer. Throughout the seasons they show white wings in flight, catching the light against blue skies—a vital clue for predators such as eagles.

- ↔ 13–15 in (33–38 cm)
- ⚖ 15–26 oz (425–737 g)
- ⊗ Common
- 🍷 Berries, shoots, leaves, seeds
- 🏠



N. North America, C. and
N. Europe, N. and C. Asia



▷ SUMMER PLUMAGE

The ptarmigan's mottled summer plumage offers camouflage, hiding it from golden eagles and Arctic foxes.